

Mobile OS Deathmatch: Google vs Apple vs Microsoft

It is literally the war of the worlds, but who will win it all?

First things first, Google's Android (since 2007), Apple's iOS (since 2008) and Microsoft's Windows Phone (successor to Windows Mobile since 2010) have been available to mobile consumers for only a few handful years now. Sure there's Nokia's Symbian, Samsung's BADA and RIM's Blackberry OS, but waning developer interest and lack of consumer support will affect their growth in the coming years. Yet, in this short but decisive period, Google, Apple and Microsoft have emerged as the strongest contenders — they currently enjoy a 69 per cent global mobile OS market share.

Android is king!

In December 2010, a total of 3 lakh Android devices (phones, tablets, etc.) were getting activated on a daily basis. That figure jumped to 5 lakh daily Android activations by June 2011, according to Android boss Andy Rubin. By December 2011, a staggering 7 lakh Android devices were getting activated worldwide on a daily basis, based on several industry estimates. At the end of September 2011, Gartner claimed Google's Android enjoyed 52.5 per cent of the global mobile OS market share, the single dominant smartphone OS on the planet! For competitors looking for a silver lining on the Android horizon, there seems no end in sight.

High on Google's agenda for 2012 is to quickly roll out Android 4.0 or Ice Cream Sandwich (ICS) as its tastefully named on a spiffy new army of fresh Android phones and tablets. ICS combines Android's variant flavours for smartphones and tablets into

one (at least for now). Launched in October last year, ICS' source code was only available in November, preceding the launch of Samsung's Galaxy Nexus smartphone—Google and Samsung's current flagship phone. Towards the middle of 2012, we expect to see a developer preview of Jelly Bean or Android 5.0, with commercial availability possible only towards the end of 2012. There's also a very strong possibility of Samsung Galaxy SIII launching in the coming months. It's a great time to be an Android user.

iOS isn't far behind

The sales of Apple's iPhone 4 (and 4S) and iPad tablets have gone through the roof, so it's quite astonishing that Apple's iOS enjoys close to 20 per cent market share on the back of only two products! Apple's a pioneer of the modern mobile ecosystem culture, with iOS being efficiently complemented by Apple's online app store and cloud syncing services to provide customers with a unique user experience. And users using iOS devices is only going to rise later this year.

Apple is set to refresh the iPad tablet as early as March 2012, with a possible iPhone 5 releasing later in the year. Apple TV is also something that's expected to launch later this year. If these aren't big enough reasons, reports have suggested that Apple is looking into "new Macs" to beat off Intel's ultrabook assault. This could mean completely new devices sporting ARM-based processors. Despite losing its founder, mentor and visionary late last year, Apple and iOS seem prepped for a bountiful 2012.

Windows Phone on the rise

There's a feel-good factor surrounding Windows Phone, right now. Everyone is bullish about its potential, and Microsoft seems to have got their act together. According to an IDC



“In the coming year we can expect ultrabooks, tablets, and all-in-one PCs to become faster and even more affordable than they are now.”

S. Rajendran, Chief Marketing Officer, Acer India

Q4 2011 Mobile Developer Report released last month, 28 per cent of developers are 'very interested' in developing apps for Windows Phone, with 48 per cent pointing the favourable attitude towards the Microsoft-Nokia partnership. Microsoft also launched a one-stop store for app downloads earlier last year.

Windows Phone uniquely combines strong elements of work (Microsoft Office) and play (Xbox LIVE) in a fresh new Metro-style tiled interface. Also unlike Google and Android, Microsoft exerts control over OEMs deploying Windows Phone devices. Of devices, expect plenty of action this year. If you wanted to buy a WP7 phone last year but couldn't afford it, this year expect a Windows Phone smartphone available at every affordable price point.

Windows Phone's current build "Mango" 7.5 will upgrade to "Tango" at CES event, while a more comprehensive upgrade, Windows Phone 8 or "Apollo" is expected by June 2012. 

USB 2.0 IS OLD

With faster USB 3.0 standard gaining momentum in 2011, witnessed on most PC boards and laptops sold last year, we expect OEMs to finally shut the door on USB 2.0 only ports on motherboards, paving the way for further proliferation of USB 3.0. What happens to users stuck with USB 2.0 devices? Don't worry, USB 3.0 will support charging and connecting of older gadgets.